TRANSFORMATION AFRICA

Product Discovery Document (PDD)

Platform-as-a-Community (PaaC) — Phase 1: Foundation & Prototype | Working Draft

Overview

Brief context: what triggered this discovery, and why now?

Transformation Africa (TA) has built a practical foundation through study trips, Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL), cross-border student projects, entrepreneurship activities, and collaboration between universities since 2024. The current briefing reports that more than 200 students have been engaged, more than 20 projects completed, and partnerships established across Africa and Europe.

As the ecosystem grows, coordination relies on fragmented tools and informal processes. This makes it harder to track students, partner organizations, opportunities, project work, outputs, and impact in one place. Phase 1 should turn the proven TA model into a structured digital Platform-as-a-Community (PaaC), without trying to build every possible feature at once.

Phase 1 should clarify the operating model, agree on the first Minimum Viable Platform (MVP), map the information the platform needs, and build a clickable or working prototype for stakeholder validation. This document is a working draft for discussion; the proposed scope and unresolved decisions are not yet stakeholder-approved.

Problem Statement

Whose problem is this, what are they trying to do, and what's getting in the way today?

Transformation Africa connects student Associates, universities, businesses, entrepreneurs, mentors, development partners, and communities through practical cross-border collaboration. These stakeholders need to find relevant people and opportunities, work together on real projects, and make project outputs and impact visible. Today, the ecosystem does not yet have one structured digital environment that supports this journey from an initial idea through to delivery and documented outcomes.

The central problem is that people, opportunities, project activities, and results are disconnected. Students need practical international project experience; universities need stronger cross-border collaboration; businesses need access to talent and innovation; entrepreneurs need multidisciplinary teams and mentors; and development partners need credible evidence of impact.

The proposed PaaC should organize the ecosystem around real projects rather than isolated profiles or separate tools. Its guiding principle is: Technology supports Relationships → Relationships create Projects → Projects create Opportunities → Opportunities create Impact. The exact workflow and terminology must be validated with TA stakeholders.

Evidence & Insights

Quantitative and qualitative signal that this problem is real. Lead with numbers, then voices.

Quantitative

- 200+ students engaged since 2024.
- 20+ projects completed.
- 5+ universities involved in South Africa and Uganda, including Stellenbosch University and Makerere University.
- Partner institutions in Austria and Germany, including MCI Innsbruck.
- ~20 pilot associates identified.

The briefing describes student engagement and partner satisfaction as very high, while noting that growth has exposed coordination bottlenecks. These observations are qualitative in the current material; a baseline and KPI framework should be established during Phase 1 rather than assuming unprovided measurements.

Qualitative / Operating Insights

- Associates are students who become members of Transformation Africa; their primary role is participation in projects and growing the network rather than coordinating or leading most projects.
- Mentors come from Business or University and may supervise multiple projects.
- Organizations are structured into two groups: Business and University.
- Opportunities may be initiated by TA Coordination, organizations, or students.
- The emerging opportunity process is intended to move from an idea to a template, then to an assignment, then to an opportunity, and ultimately into a project.
- Organizations are expected to be able to create opportunities and potentially view applicants and project teams; exact permissions remain to be confirmed.

Problem Impact

What does it cost the ecosystem if we do nothing? Be specific where evidence exists.

If Transformation Africa does not create a unified ecosystem structure:

- Growth will continue to increase coordination complexity and reliance on fragmented tools.
- Opportunity visibility will remain limited, making it harder for students and other stakeholders to discover relevant projects and collaboration paths.
- Cross-border project coordination will remain dependent on manual processes and individual relationships.
- The ecosystem will have less consistent visibility into skills, project participation, talent demand, and competency gaps.
- The ability to measure and demonstrate verified social and economic impact will remain fragmented.
- Potential connections between education, employment, entrepreneurship, business innovation, and development impact may be lost or delayed.

The source material does not quantify these impacts in monetary terms, so this document does not introduce financial estimates. Phase 1 should define practical indicators such as opportunities published, student applications, projects started and completed, partner participation, outputs approved for sharing, and outcomes documented.

Possible Solutions

2–4 directions worth considering, with honest pros and cons. Don't pre-commit.

Option	Summary	Pros	Cons
A. Opportunity-to-Project MVP	Build the first core workflow around the transformation of ideas into structured assignments, opportunities, selected teams, and projects.	Directly reflects the emerging operating model; gives the platform a clear core workflow; creates a strong foundation for later portals.	Many stakeholder features remain outside the first MVP; approval and selection rules still need definition.
B. Five-Portal MVP	Prototype the five connected environments: Student Associate,	Makes the full ecosystem visible; supports stakeholder-	Higher scope and complexity; risks building screens before the

	University, Business, Innovation, and Governance.	specific experiences; aligns closely with the strategic architecture.	underlying workflows are validated.
C. Project-Centered Ecosystem MVP	Treat projects as the central object and connect Associates, organizations, mentors, opportunities, teams, and outcomes around each project.	Strong alignment with the 'Real Projects' principle; naturally connects learning, business, mentorship, talent and impact.	Requires careful data and permission design; some portal functionality may need to be introduced later.
D. Prototype + Validation First	Create a clickable/working prototype of the core ecosystem and test it with selected partner hubs before committing to full platform development.	Reduces build risk; validates workflows and terminology with real stakeholders; supports Phase 1's stated prototype objective.	Requires disciplined feedback and decision-making; prototype findings may change initial assumptions.

Risks & Unknowns

The following are the main unresolved decisions to validate before detailed implementation:

- Opportunity governance: the current material does not yet specify who formally approves opportunities or applications.
- Workflow definitions: the exact distinction between an idea, template, assignment, opportunity, and project needs to be documented.
- Project conversion: it is not yet established whether every opportunity becomes a project or what criteria trigger conversion.
- Team selection: who selects final project teams and how applications are assessed is not yet defined.
- Permissions: organization access to applicants and project teams has been proposed, but the precise permission model is still open.
- Mentorship rules: it is confirmed that one mentor may supervise multiple projects, but the maximum number of mentors per project is not yet specified.

- Eligibility and matching: the exact rules for who can discover/apply for which opportunities are not yet defined.
- AI governance: AI is intended to support matching, portfolio analytics and impact reporting, while humans retain decision-making authority. Detailed AI governance requirements still need to be formalized.
- Data privacy and ethics: the strategic briefing places comprehensive privacy and ethics formalization in Phase 2, so Phase 1 must avoid assuming final policy decisions that have not yet been approved.
- Sustainability: Phase 1 must establish the foundation for sustainability and revenue logic, while detailed financial sustainability and monetization models are planned for Phase 2.
- Scope risk: attempting to build all five portals simultaneously could produce a broad but weak MVP unless the core workflow is prioritized.

Recommendations & Next Steps

What you're recommending, why, and what happens next.

Recommendation: proceed with Phase 1 discovery and prototype validation, using a project-centered workflow as the main functional thread.

A focused MVP should prioritize partner-university and student case/project workflows, with a structured record of opportunities, teams, mentors, project progress, and approved outputs. Include a public-facing information area and a library of approved project outputs if stakeholders confirm these as Phase 1 needs. Do not assume that open company case submission, a full industry portal, a separate Innovation portal, or deep integration with the existing training platform are MVP requirements until TA confirms them.

Recommended next steps:

- 1. Confirm the primary MVP users and first partner-university workflows.
- 2. Agree on the meaning and relationship of Idea, Template, Assignment, Opportunity, Application, Team, Project, Output, and Impact Record.
- 3. Map the opportunity-to-project lifecycle, including who can create, review, approve, publish, and close each item.
- 4. Define permissions for Associates, Mentors, University organizations, Business organizations, and TA Coordination.
- 5. Prioritize a small set of user journeys before designing every portal or dashboard.

- 6. Document user stories, functional requirements, core data fields, and the initial data model.
- 7. Prototype the prioritized workflows and test them with selected TA stakeholders.
- 8. Agree on initial KPIs, privacy and publication checks, and a simple risk register.
- 9. Record decisions, assumptions, and unresolved questions; obtain leadership sign-off before implementation.

Guiding principle: “Transformation Africa is a Platform-as-a-Community where real people meet on real projects that create real business and real impact.”